Addis Ababa Science and Technology University
College of Social Science And Humanities

Course Title: Social Anthropology (Anth 1012)

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Unit 1: Introducing Anthropology & its Subject Matter

- **Unit objectives:**

- **define anthropology**& **explain** concepts in anthropology,
- express **the scope & subject matter of anthropology**,
- internalize the **unique features** of anthropology,
- get cleared with the **misconceptions** about anthropology,
- explain the **contributions** of anthropology

Definition & Concepts Anthropology

- Etymology of the term ***Anthropology***: two Greek words:

  'anthropos' ('human being/mankind') &

  'logos', ('reason/study/science').
- So, anthropology means '**reason about humans**' or '**the study or science of humankind or humanity**'.
- Man has **two** important characteristics:

  1. biological
  2. cultural which are inseparable

elements. Studying man/human involves understanding the

Biological & the **cultural characteristics**

Culture influences human physical structures & vise-versa

- **The way we eat, cook, explore and interact with others can influence our genes**

- Literally, anthropology is the study of **humans**.
- In one sense, this is an accurate description to the extent that anthropology raises a **wide variety of questions** about the human condition.
- Yet, this literal definition is not particularly illuminating;
- Because a number of other academic disciplines—including sociology, biology, psychology, political science, economics, and history—also study human beings.
- **What distinguishes anthropology from all of these disciplines?**

Anthropology is

- **the study of people-**
- their **origins**,
- their **development, and**
- **contemporary variations**, **wherever** and **whenever** they have been found.

It is a **broad** scientific **discipline dedicated to the comparative study of humans as a group;**

- **from its first appearance on earth to its present stage of development**

More specifically anthropology :

1. Investigates the strategies for living that are learned and shared by people as members of human social groups;

2. Examines the characteristics that human beings share as members of one species (homo sapiens) and the diverse ways that people live in different environments;

3. Analyses the **products of social groups**:

- **material objects** (material cultures) and
- **non-material creations** (religion/beliefs, social values, institutions, practices, etc.)

- Anthropology: intellectually challenging, theoretically ambitious subject.
- It tries to achieve an understanding of culture, society & humanity through detailed studies of community life, supplemented by comparison.
- At the deepest level, it raises philosophical questions, which it tries to respond to by exploring human lives under different conditions.
- Anthropology seeks to explain how & why people are both **similar** & **different** through examination of our biological &cultural past & comparative study of contemporary human societies.

The ultimate goal of anthropology:

- to develop an integrated picture of humankind —
- a goal that encompasses an almost **infinite number** of questions about all aspects of our existence:

- Anthropology primarily offers **two kinds of insight**

- **First** , the discipline **produces knowledge about the actual biological and cultural variations in the world**

- **Second** , anthropology **offers methods and theoretical perspectives enabling practitioners to explore, compare, understand and solve societal problems**

Historical Development of Anthropology

- Anthropology is a fairly recent discipline.
- Anthropology, considered as the **science of humanity** ,originated In ‘Western’ countries: France, Great Britain, the USA and, Germany
- The present academic anthropology has its roots in the works and ideas of the great ancient and Medieval Greek, Roman, and Hebrew philosophers and social thinkers.

- Generally speaking, anthropology as an academic discipline was born during the 19th century, out of the intellectual atmosphere of **Enlightenment**
- which is the eighteenth century social and philosophical movement that emphasized human progress and the poser of reason, and based on the **Darwinian Theory of Evolution.**
- **By the late 1870s**, anthropology was beginning to emerge as a profession. due to expansion of **western colonial powers** and their consequent desire to better understand the peoples **living under colonial domination.**

- During its formative years(in the 1870s and 1880s), anthropology became a profession primarily in museums.

- Early anthropologists mainly studied small communities who were technologically simple societies.
- Such societies are often called by various names:
- "traditional", "non-industrialized and/or simple societies".

Anthropologists of the early 1900s emphasized the study of social & cultural differences among human groups.

- Many of the indigenous peoples of non-western world & their social & cultural features were studied in detail & documented. This approach is called **ethnography**

- By the mid-1900, however, anthropologists attempted to discover universal human patterns & the common bio-psychological traits that bind all humans.
- This approach is called **ethnology**

- Ethnology: the comparative understanding & analysis of different ethnic groups across time & space.

- In Ethiopia, - intensive anthropological study **began since the 1950's**,

  - and it was focusing on **ethnographic study** – ways of life and customs.

1.5. Unique Features of Anthropology

what makes anthropology unique?

- unique in its scope, approach, focus and method

I. Broader Scope = It is interested in

- **all human beings** (contemporary and past; primitive and civilized)
- **Different aspects of humans** (phenotype x-ics, family types, marriages, political systems, economic lives, belief systems, technology, health care systems, personality types, and languages and the like)

No place and time are too remote

- Indeed, Anthropology is the broad study of human kind, around the world & throughout time.

Uniqueness…

II. The second important feature is its **approach:**

- *Holistic* , *relativistic* , & *focused* one.

1. Holistic, means that it looks any phenomena from different angles (e.g., culture, history, language, and biology)

2. Relativism is highly appreciated in anthropology.

- It tries to study & explain a certain belief, practice or institution or a group of people in its **own context**.
- It does **not make value judgment**, i.e., it does not hold the position that a given belief or practice is ‘good’ or ‘bad’.

Uniqueness…

3. ***Focused*** **one.**

Another important perspective :**insiders' views (emic view)** .

- Anthropological studies give attention to how people perceive themselves &understand their world& how a particular group of people explain about their action, or give meaning to their ,or cultural practices.
- = help to study in detail and search for multiple meanings/'realities'
  - **Etic view:** outsiders` view

Unique Features …

III. Research approach/Method = often relies on **qualitative research design**

= use **ethnographic research approach**

= data collection instruments: **participant observation, in-depth and key informant interviews, and FGD** (focus-group discussion)

1.6. Misconceptions about Anthropology

- Highly related with its areas of study

1) limited to the study of ‘primitive’ society (right in the past)

   however, nowadays, it also studies advanced and complex societies

2) only study rural people and rural area (yes, in the past)

   however, today, it also studies urban people and landscape (e.g., urban anthropology or organizational anthropology)

3) focus on fossil evidences of proto-humans like that of ***Lucy/Dinkinesh*** . (yes, in the past and even today to look for origin/evolution of mankind)

- however, it is also about biological and cultural aspects, and the current physical and biological variations and cultural diversities

4) The purpose is only about preserving the culture of communities far from development and caring heritages in the museum

- but aims to help them air their voices and empower their capacity to challenge top-down approaches

1.7. The Relationships between Anthropology and Other Disciplines

= similar with the social sciences.

- Anthropology is similar with other social sciences such as sociology, psychology, political sciences, economics, history, etc. Anthropology greatly overlaps with these disciplines that study human society.

- = however, differs from them in its **broad scope**, **unique approach** (holistically, comparatively, and relativistic),

- **perspective** (experiences, thoughts, and feelings; and naturalistic and ideographic-particularizing, not nomothetic-universalizing, unit of analysis, and methods (extended fieldwork) used.

- In its method of research, it is unique in that it undertakes extended fieldwork among the study community and develops intimate knowledge of the life and social worlds of its study group/society through employing those ethnographic data collection techniques such as participant observation, key informant interview and focus group discussions.

1.8. Contributions of Anthropology

- **Comparative study-** to understand as **our culture** is just one way of lives among many in the world.
- **Insights** – to know **social and cultural diversity** (how our decisions affect others & vice versa)
- **Help us understand how local cultural groups are engaging** with the processes of **globalization**

Contributions …

- Help us to be more **sensitive to and appreciative of cultural diversity** and variability
  - to fight against **prejudice and discrimination**
  - to fight against **ethnocentrism**
- A tool **for development**
  - to pay **attention to local conditions** that is crucial to solve communities' problems
  - to ensure peoples' **right to development**
  - to **sustain projects' life**
  - to know **locals' needs and interests for development**
  - to **materialize culturally appropriate and socially sensitive** projects
  - to protect the **locals from harmful projects**

Unit Two: Sub-fields of Anthropology

This Unit deals with the major sub-fields of anthropology.

Anthropology is often divided into four major subfields:

1. **Archeological Anthropology**
2. **Linguistic Anthropology and**
3. **Socio-Cultural Anthropology**.
4. **Physical/Biological Anthropology**

2.1 Archaeological Anthropology

- Archaeology studies the ways of lives of past peoples by excavating and analyzing the material culture/physical remains they left behind.

- Archaeological Anthropology is a branch of anthropology that focuses on the study of human culture and behavior through the examination of material remains, such as artifacts, structures, and landscapes.

- **Artifacts** are *material remains made and used by the past peoples* and *that can be removed from the site and taken to the laboratory for further analysis* (such as Tools, ornaments, arrowheads, coins, pottery)

- **Features** are *like artifacts, are made or modified by past people, but they cannot be readily carried away from the site* (ruins, house foundations, ancient buildings, fireplaces, steles).

- **Eco-facts** are *non-artefactual, organic and environmental remains* such as soil, animal bones, and plant

2.1 Archaeological Anthropology

- By analyzing the physical evidence left behind by past societies, archaeologists piece together the stories of these cultures and gain a deeper understanding of their beliefs, practices, and technological advancements.

- This field encompasses a range of time periods, from prehistory to recent history, and draws upon various methodologies, including **excavation**, lab analysis, and comparative studies.
- The results of archaeological research provide valuable insights into the development of human societies, cultural continuity and change, and the relationships between people and their environments.

- Subfields of Archaeology:
  1. ***Prehistoric Archaeology:***
     - investigates human prehistory and prehistoric cultures b/n 2.5million years ago to 6000 years
  2. ***Historical Archaeology***
     - reconstruct the cultures of people after using inventing art writing & use language since about 6,000 years ago

2.2. **Linguistic Anthropology**

- Linguistic anthropology generally focuses on the evolution of languages by studying contemporary human languages as well as those of the past.

- It studies language in context, revealing how people's ways of communicating and expressing themselves interact with human culture, history, politics, identity, and much more.
- It examines the relationships between language, culture, and society.
- *Language* most distinctive feature of being human.

4 Sub-fields of linguistic anthropology

***1.Structural /Descriptive* Linguistics: -**studies the structure of linguistic patterns (sound, grammar, meanings, rules)

2. Ethno-linguistics (*cultural linguistics):* examines the relationship between language and culture.

3. Historical linguistics:

- deals with the emergence of language in general and how specific languages have diverged over time.
- It focuses on the comparison and classifications of different languages to differentiate the historical links between them.

4. Socio-linguistics: -investigates linguistic variation within a given language (dialectics, bilingual)

2.3. Socio-Cultural Anthropology

It focus on the study of society and culture, while often interested in cultural diversity and universalism

- **Society** is the group of people who have similar ways of life,
- **culture** is a way of life of a group of people.
  - Society and culture are two sides of the same coin.
- It studies social, cultural and material life of contemporary human societies.
  - social (human relations), symbolic or nonmaterial (religious, language, and any other symbols) and material (all man-made objects)

Socio-Cultural Anthropology has two aspects of study

***1.* Ethnography** (based on field work)-

- provides a comprehensive account of a particular community, society, or culture.
- detailed descriptions of specific cultures (behavior, beliefs, customs, social life, economic activities, politics, and religion).
- extensive fieldwork (ethnographic fieldwork-2 years), observes, talks to, lives with the people he or she is studying and build and present that account in the form of a book, article, or film

2. Ethnology –*(*based on cross-cultural comparison)

- comparative study of **contemporary cultures and societies**
  - It examines, interprets, analyzes, and compares the results of **ethnographic** the data gathered in different societies.
  - seek to understand **why people differ** (now & past) and what all cultures in the world have in **common with one another**.

2.4. Physical/Biological Anthropology

- It is a branch of anthropology that focuses on the biological and behavioral aspects of human beings.

- It has sub-fields such as
  - Primatology -the scientific study of primates, especially nonhuman primates
  - Forensic anthropology
  - Paleoanthropology,
  - Population genetics, and
  - Human ecology –

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Ecology is the study of the relationships between living organisms and their interactions with their natural or developed environment

In this regard, the subfields of physical anthropology are closely related to natural sciences, particularly biology.

Physical anthropologists study:

- How **culture** and **environment** have influenced **biological** evolution and contemporary human **variations**.

  - Biology affects culture (sexual labor division, marriage)
  - Culture affect biology (food preferences, sexuality)

Human sexuality is the way people experience and express themselves sexually. This involves biological, psychological, physical, erotic, emotional, social, or spiritual feelings and behaviors.

- Biological variations are the result of the cumulative processes of invisible changes passed through **genes**. The major sources of biological variations (**natural selection**, **geographical isolation**, **genetic** mutation.

There are two major areas of research in physical anthropology:

1)human evolution, and 2) modern human variation.

1. **Human evolution** is the study of the gradual processes of simple forms into more differentiated structures in hominid (**member of primate family including humans**)

- It is interested in reconstructing the evolutionary record of the human species using fossils/bones. Human evolution is further divided into specialties:
    a. *Paleoanthropology*- (*paleo* meaning —old‖) study evolution through the analysis of fossil remains from prehistoric times
    b. *Primatology*- studies about primates (gorillas and chimpanzees)as recent human ancestors in an effort to gain clues about our own evolution as a species.

2. **Human genetics** concerns to investigate how and why the physical traits of contemporary human populations vary throughout the world. It focuses to **examine the genetic materials of an organism such as DNA and RNA**.

2.4.1. Evolutionary and Paleo-anthropological perspectives on human origin

- Comprehensive theories of evolution concerning the evolution of life were developed only during the 19th century.
- Anthropologists today rely on scientific views of evolution in order to explain human origins.
- **Evolution** refers to a process and gradual change in specie over time.

- In fact, evolution is used to describe the **cumulative effects** of three independent facts.
- Importantly, these attributes of evolution can be observed in nature every day. They are:

- **Replication:** The fact that life forms have offspring;
- **Variation:** The fact that each offspring is slightly different from its parents, and its siblings; and
- **Selection:** The fact that not all offspring survive, and those that do tend to be the ones best suited to their environment.

Human Origin…

- The scientific explanation of human origin and the concept of evolution are attributed to a series of discoveries of early modern period and the works of handful of scientists in the physical/natural sciences.

- One of the prominent persons in this regard is Charles Darwin (1809-1882), a British Naturalist of the period.

- Charles Darwin is known for his theory of **natural selection** in the evolution of species and the idea of **survival of the fittest**.

Human Origin…

Today, anthropologists have accumulated a huge amount of data, much of it based on studies of **DNA**, the molecule that shapes all Earth life, to back the claims Darwin made in 1859.

- In doing so, anthropologists study humanity as a biological phenomenon by raising questions such as:

  - What species are we most and least like?
  - Where and when did we fist appear?
  - What were our ancestors like?

2.4.2 Anthropological perspectives on racial types and human physical variation

- People come in many colors and shapes
- Why is this? How did these variations come about, and what do they mean for humanity as a species?
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- The answer comes from the study of human biology by physical anthropologists.
- How human populations have adapted to their varying environments by the same evolutionary process that shapes all living things from the perspective of race?.

2.4.2 Anthropological perspectives on racial types and human physical variation

- Like all living things with sensory input, humans have to classify their perceptions into some kind of order:
- Some people have darker skin, so they‘re in the darker skin category.
- humans have spent some time putting people of different colors, body shapes, and so on into different categories sometimes called races.
- Biologically speaking, **a race** is a group of organisms of the same species that share similar physical (and genetic) attributes and specific geographic regions.